

Medication Management and Reconciliation Policy

Aligned to the RACGP Standards for general practices (6th edition, published August 2026)

1. Policy Title

Medication Management and Reconciliation Policy

2. Purpose

This policy describes how [Practice Name] ensures safe prescribing, dispensing, administration, and reconciliation of medicines. It aligns with criterion CG4 – Provision of clinical and medicines guidelines of the RACGP Standards for general practices (6th edition).

3. Scope

This policy applies to all clinical staff at [Practice Name] involved in prescribing, dispensing, administering, or reconciling medicines, including sample medications.

4. Definitions

- Medication reconciliation: The process of identifying the most accurate list of a patient's medicines and comparing it against current orders to identify and resolve discrepancies.
- High-risk medicines: Medicines with a heightened risk of significant harm when used in error (e.g., insulin, opioids, anticoagulants, methotrexate).
- Medicine samples: complimentary starter packs supplied by pharmaceutical companies.
- Adverse drug event: Any injury resulting from medical intervention related to a drug.
- Antimicrobial stewardship: Coordinated actions to promote the appropriate use of antimicrobials and reduce inappropriate antibiotic prescribing (criterion CG4.D).

5. Principles

[Practice Name] commits to the following medicines management principles:

- Patient safety at every step of the medicines pathway.
- Accurate, current medication records reconciled at transitions of care.
- Safe storage, handling, and disposal of medicines.
- Electronic prescribing and clinical decision support used to reduce error.
- Continuous monitoring and improvement of medicines-related safety events.

6. Medication Reconciliation

Medication reconciliation must occur at defined points, including new patient registration, hospital discharge, and after specialist review:

- Collect a best-possible medication history (including over-the-counter and complementary medicines).
- Confirm the history with at least one other source (e.g., dispensing record, hospital discharge summary, My Health Record, carer).
- Document the reconciled medicine list in the patient's electronic health record using SNOMED CT-AU coded entries.
- Identify and resolve discrepancies in collaboration with the treating GP.

7. Prescribing

- Prescriptions are generated through the clinical software using current, SNOMED CT-AU coded medicine entries.
- Clinical decision support (allergy and interaction checking) must not be overridden without clinical justification documented in the record.
- High-risk medicines require additional safeguards, including dose verification and, where appropriate, a second-clinician check.
- Adverse drug reactions are recorded in the patient's record and reconciled at each visit.

8. Antimicrobial Stewardship (Criterion CG4.D)

- The clinical team has access to current information and resources to reduce inappropriate antibiotic prescribing (e.g., Therapeutic Guidelines antibiotic guidance and RACGP antimicrobial prescribing resources).
- Patients have access to information and resources on appropriate antibiotic use, including why antibiotics are not always required.
- Antibiotic prescribing is reviewed as part of the practice's clinical audit program, and findings feed into quality improvement.

9. Storage and Handling

- Medicines stored securely with access restricted to authorised staff.
- S8 (controlled) and S4 (restricted) medicines stored in a locked, fixed safe/cabinet with a current drug register.
- Vaccines and cold chain-dependent medicines managed under the Cold Chain Management Policy.
- Emergency medicines (e.g., oxygen, adrenaline for anaphylaxis) kept in a clearly marked, accessible location and checked monthly for expiry and stock levels.
- Expired and unwanted medicines disposed of via an authorised waste contractor; stock destroyed under supervision and recorded.

10. Sample Medications

- Sample medications are stored securely and recorded on a stock register.
- Samples are not used past their expiry date.
- Distribution to patients is documented in the patient's clinical record.

11. Roles and Responsibilities

GPs:

- Prescribe medicines in accordance with current Therapeutic Guidelines.
- Reconcile medicines at transitions of care.

Practice nurses:

- Support medication reconciliation by collecting medication histories.
- Manage medication samples and emergency drug stock checks.

Practice Manager:

- Ensure secure storage, drug register currency, and audit compliance.
- Maintain this policy and ensure staff training.

12. Education and Training

- All clinical staff receive medicines safety training at induction.
- Annual refresher training on high-risk medicines, allergies, and reconciliation.

13. Monitoring, Audit, and Review

- Quarterly audit of medication samples, emergency drug stock, and S8/S4 registers.
- Quarterly audit of antibiotic prescribing against current guidelines as part of the quality improvement program.
- Review of all medicines-related incidents and near misses.
- Annual review of this policy.

14. Documentation and Record Keeping

The practice maintains:

- Reconciled medication lists in each patient's electronic health record.
- S8 and S4 drug registers.
- Stock registers for samples and emergency medicines.
- Medication incident reports and outcomes.
- Antibiotic audit results and improvement actions.
- Staff training records.

15. References

- The Royal Australian College of General Practitioners. Standards for general practices (6th edition). East Melbourne, Vic: RACGP; published 26 August 2026. Available at: <https://www.racgp.org.au/running-a-practice/practice-standards/standards-6th-edition>
- Therapeutic Guidelines. Available at: <https://www.tg.org.au>
- Australian Commission on Safety and Quality in Health Care. Antimicrobial stewardship. Available at: <https://www.safetyandquality.gov.au>
- Australian Commission on Safety and Quality in Health Care. National Medication Management Plan. Available at: <https://www.safetyandquality.gov.au>
- NPS MedicineWise. Available at: <https://www.nps.org.au>

Version Control

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